



HISTORY OF ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN, HIES2010

CHAPTER ONE : INTRODUCTION

1.1.NATURE OF HISTORY

- The term history derived from the Greek word Istoria, means “inquiry” or “an account of one’s inquiries.” The first use of the term is attributed to one of the ancient Greek historians, Herodotus (c. 484-425 B.C), who is often held to be the “father of history.”
- Academically, history can be defined as an organized and systematic study of the past. The study involves the discovery, collection, organization, and presentation of information about past events

....NATURE OF HISTORY

- ◉ In this regard, the major concern of history is the study of human society and its interaction with the natural environment, which is also the subject of study by many other disciplines. What differentiates history from other disciplines is that while the latter study the interaction between humans and their environment in the present state, history studies the interaction between the two in the past within the framework of the continuous process of change taking place in time.

1.2.USES OF STUDYING HISTORY

- Peoples live in the present and they plan for and worry about the future. History, however, is the study of the past. Why bother with the past while living in the present and anticipating what is yet to come?
- 1. History Helps Better Understand the Present
- 2. History Provides a Sense of Identity

...USES OF HISTORY

- ◉ 3. History Teaches Critical Skills
 - ◉ Studying history helps students to develop key research skills. These include how to find and evaluate sources; how to make coherent arguments based on various kinds of evidence and present clearly in writing. These analytical and communication skills are highly usable in other academic pursuits. Gaining skills in sorting through diverse interpretations is also essential to make informed decisions in our day-to-day life.
- ◉ 4. History Helps Develop Tolerance and Open-Mindedness
- ◉ 5. History Supplies Endless Source of Fascination

1.3.SOURCES AND METHODS OF HISTORICAL STUDIES

- ◉ Historical sources are broadly classified into two types: Primary and Secondary.
- ◉ 1.Primary sources are surviving traces of the past available to us in the present. They are original or first hand in their proximity to the event both in time and in space. Examples of primary sources are manuscripts (handwritten materials), diaries, letters, minutes, court records and administrative files, travel documents, photographs, maps, video and audiovisual materials, and artifacts such as coins, fossils, weapons, utensils, and buildings.
- ◉ 2. Secondary sources, on the other hand, are second-hand published accounts about past events. They are written long after the event has occurred, providing an interpretation of what happened, why it happened, and how it happened, often based on primary sources.

... SOURCES AND METHODS OF HISTORICAL STUDIES

- ◉ Examples of secondary sources are articles, books, textbooks, biographies, and published stories or movies about historical events. Secondary materials give us what appear to be finished accounts of certain historical periods and phenomena. Nevertheless, no history work can be taken as final, as new sources keep coming to light. New sources make possible new historical interpretations or entirely new historical reconstructions.

1.4. CRITICAL ANALYSIS OF SOURCES

- ◉ For the history of Ethiopia and the Horn, historians use a combination of the sources described above. However, whatever the source of information-primary or secondary, written or oral- the data should be subjected to critical evaluation before used as evidence.
- ◉ Primary sources have to be verified for their originality and authenticity because sometimes primary sources like letters may be forged. Secondary sources have to be examined for the reliability of their reconstructions. Oral data may lose its originality and authenticity due to distortion through time. Therefore, it should be crosschecked with other sources such as written documents to determine its veracity or authenticity. In short, historians (unlike novelists) must find evidence about the past, ask questions of that evidence, and come up with explanations that make sense of what the evidence says about the people, events, places and time periods they study about.

1.5.HISTORIOGRAPHY OF ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN

- Historiography can be defined as the history of historical writing, studying how knowledge of the past, either recent or distant, is obtained and transmitted.
- The organized study and narration of the past was introduced by ancient Greek historians notably Herodotus and Thucydides (c.455-400 B.C.E.) . The other major tradition of thinking and writing about the past is the Chinese. The most important early figure in Chinese historical thought and writing was the Han dynasty figure Sima Qian (145-86 B.C.E.).

...HISTORIOGRAPHY OF ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN

- History emerged as an academic discipline in the second half of the nineteenth century first in Europe and subsequently in other parts of the world including the US.
- The German historian, Leopold Von Ranke (1795-1886), and his colleagues established history as an independent discipline in Berlin with its own set of methods and concepts by which historians collect evidence of past events, evaluate that evidence, and present a meaningful discussion of the subject. Ranke's greatest contribution to the scientific study of the past is such that he is considered as the "father of modern historiography."

...HISTORIOGRAPHY OF ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN

- ◉ The earliest known reference that we have on history of Ethiopia and the Horn is the Periplus of the Erythrean Sea, written in the first century A.D by an anonymous author. Another document describing Aksum's trade and the then Aksumite king's campaigns on both sides of the sea is the Christian Topography composed by Cosmas Indicopleustes, a Greek sailor, in the sixth century A.D.

1.6. SOURCES ON ETHIOPIAN HISTORY : HAGIOGRAPHIES AND KITABS

- Inscriptions aside, the earliest written Ethiopian material dates from the seventh century A.D. The document was found in Abba Gerima monastery in Yeha. This was followed by a manuscript discovered in Haiq Istifanos monastery of present day Wollo in the thirteenth century A.D. The value of manuscripts is essentially religious. Yet, for historians, they have the benefit of providing insights into the country's past.
- For example, the manuscript cited above contains the list of medieval kings and their history in brief. The largest groups of sources available for medieval Ethiopian history are hagiographies originating from Ethiopian Orthodox Church. Invariably written in Ge'ez, an important function of hagiographies is enhancing the prestige of saints.

1.6.1.HAGIOGRAPHIES AND KITABS

- ◉ A parallel hagiographical tradition existed among Muslim communities of the country. One such account offers tremendous insight into the life of a Muslim saint, Shaykh Ja'far Bukko of Gattira, in present day Wollo, in the late nineteenth century. Besides the saint's life, the development of indigenous Islam and contacts between the region's Muslim community and the outside world are some of the issues discussed in this document.

....CHRONICLES AND KITABS

- ◉ Ethiopia had also an indigenous tradition of history writing called chronicles. Chronicles in the ancient Ethiopian Ge'ez tongue first appeared in the fourteenth century and continue (sometimes in Amharic) into the early twentieth. Kings or their successors entrusted the writing of chronicles to court scribes or clergymen of recognized clerical training and calligraphic skills.
- ◉ The earliest and the last of such surviving documents are the Glorious Victories of Amde-Tsion and the Chronicle of Abeto Iyasu and Empress Zewditu respectively. Chronicles incorporate both legends and facts-past and contemporary about the monarch's genealogy, upbringing military exploits, piety and statesmanship. Chronicles are known for their factual detail and strong chronological framework, even if it would require considerable labor to convert their relative chronology to an absolute one. It is also averse to quantification, have a limitation (Bias and Chronology).

1.6.2. ARABIC DOCUMENTS

- For example, al-Masudi and Ibn Battuta described the culture, language and import-export trade in the main central region of the east African coast in the tenth and in the fourteenth centuries respectively. For the 16th and 17th centuries we have two documents composed by Yemeni writers who were eyewitnesses to the events they described. The first document titled *Futuh al Habesha* was composed by Shihab al-Din, who recorded the conflict between the Christian kingdom and the Muslim principalities in the sixteenth century.
- The other first-hand account was left to us by Al-Haymi, who led a Yemeni delegation in 1647 to the court of Fasiledas (r. 1632-67).

1.6.3. TRAVEL ACCOUNT

- ◉ The contribution of European missionaries and travelers to the development of Ethiopian historiography is also significant. From the early sixteenth until the late nineteenth centuries, missionaries (Catholics and Protestants) came to the country with the intention of staying, and who, nevertheless, maintained intimate links with Europe.
- ◉ Thus, the missionaries' sources provide us with valuable information covering a considerable period. Some of the major topics covered by these sources include religious and political developments within Ethiopia, and the country's foreign relations. An example of such account is *The Prester John of the Indies*, composed by a Portuguese priest, Francisco Alvarez who accompanied the Portuguese mission to the court of Lebne-Dengel in 1520.

...TRAVEL ACCOUNT

- ◉ In addition to the missionary sources, travel documents had important contribution to the development of Ethiopian historiography. One example of travel documents is James Bruce's Travels to Discover the Source of the Nile. Like other sources, however, both the missionaries and travelers' materials can only be used with considerable reservations and with care for they are socially and politically biased.

1.7.THE PROFESSIONALIZATION OF HISTORY IN OTHER PARTS OF THE HORN

- ◉ The professionalization of history in other parts of the Horn is a post-colonial phenomenon. With the establishment of independent nations, a deeper interest in exploring their own past quickly emerged among African populations, perhaps stimulated by reactions to decades of education in an alien imperial historiography.
- ◉ With this came an urgent need to recast the historical record and to recover evidence of many lost pre-colonial civilizations. The decolonization of African historiography required new methodological approach (tools of investigation) to the study of the past that involved a critical use of oral data and tapping the percepts of ancillary disciplines like archeology, anthropology and linguistics.

1.8. GEOGRAPHICAL CONTEXT

- ◉ The term “Ethiopia and the Horn” refers to that part of Northeast Africa, which now contains the countries of Djibouti, Eritrea, Ethiopia, and Somalia. The region consists chiefly of mountains uplifted through the formation of the Great Rift Valley.
- ◉ The major physiographic features of the region are a massive highland complex of mountains and plateaus divided by the Great Rift Valley and surrounded by lowlands, semi-desert, deserts and tropical forests along the periphery. The diversity of the terrain led to regional variations in climate, natural vegetation, soil composition, and settlement patterns. As with the physical features, people across the region are remarkably diverse: they speak a vast number of different languages, profess to many distinct religions, live in a variety types of dwellings, and engage in a wide range of economic activities.

... GEOGRAPHICAL CONTEXT

- ◉ The history of Ethiopia and the Horn has been shaped by contacts with others through commerce, migrations, wars, slavery, colonialism, and the waxing and waning of state systems. Yet, the evolution of human history owed much to geographical factors notably location, landforms, resource endowment, climate and drainage systems which continue to impact, as incentives and deterrents, the movement of people and goods in the region.
- ◉ Another element of geography factor that had profound impact on human history is drainage system. Ethiopia and the Horn has five principal drainage systems. These are the Nile River, Gibe/Omo-Gojeb, Genale/Jubba-Shebele, the Awash River, and the Ethiopian Rift Valley Lakesystems. Ethiopia and the Horn can be divided into three major distinct environmental zones



PEOPLES AND CULTURES IN ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN

CHAPTER TWO

ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN

- Ethiopia and the Horn is referred to as the cradle of humankind. It is also a region where early civilizations including food production, making tools and religion took place. These developments contributed to the social evolutions, economic formations, and socio-cultural and political settings.

2. HUMAN EVOLUTION

- Archeological evidences suggest that East African Rift Valley is a cradle of humanity. Evidences related to both biological and cultural evolution have been discovered in 1.the **Lower Omo and**
- **2., Middle Awash** River valleys
- both by Ethiopian and foreign scholars.

PALEONTOLOGICAL RESEARCHES IN ETHIOPIA

- ◉ .A fossil named Chororapithecus dated 10 million B. P. was unearthed in Anchar (in West Hararghe) in 2007.
- ◉ Ardipithicus Ramiduskadabba (dated 5.8-5.2 million years BP) was discovered in Middle Awash.

PALEONTOLOGICAL RESEARCHES IN ETHIOPIA

- *Ardipithecus ramidus* (dated 4. 2 million B.P.) was discovered at Aramis in Afar in 1994. Other
- Australopithecines were uncovered at Belohdelie (dated back 3.6 million years B. P.) in Middle Awash.
- A three years old child's fossil termed as *Australopithecus afarensis*, Selam, dated to 3.3 million years B.P was also discovered at Dikika, Mille, Afar in 2000.

HUMAN EVOLUTION

THE AFARNESIS AND ANAMENSIS CONNECTION

- Another Australopithecus afarnesis (Lucy/Dinkinesh, dated c. 3.18 million years B. P.) with 40% complete body parts, weight 30kg, height 1.07 meters and pelvis looks like bipedal female was discovered at Hadar in Afar in 1974 A. D.
- Fossil named Australopithecus Anamensis was discovered around [Lake Turkana](#).
- An eco-fact named as **Australopithecus Garhi** (means surprise in Afar language) dated to 2.5 million years B.P was discovered at Bouri, Middle Awash, between 1996 and 1999.

GENUS HOMO

- . The development of the human brain was to be the main feature of the next stage of human evolution, which produced the genus Homo, believed to have emerged 2-2.5 million years B.P. Different evidences of the genus homo have been recovered in different parts of Ethiopia and the Horn.
- A partial skull of a fossil termed as Homo habilis, which is derived from Latin terms "Homo" (human being) and "Habilis" (skillful use of hands), dated 1.9 million years B. P. has been found in the Lower Omo.
- A fossil named Homo erectus (walking upright, dated 1. 6 million years B. P.) was discovered at Melka Kunture, Konso Gardula and Gadeb with 900-1100 cc brain size.

HOMO ERECTUS, HOMO SAPIENS SAPIENS

- Homo erectus seems to have originated in Africa and then spread out to the rest of the world. Skeleton of Archaic Homosapiens (knowledgeable human being, dated 400, 000 years B.P.) named **Bodo with brain size of 1300-1400cc was discovered in Middle Awash.**
- Fossils of Homo sapiens sapiens (100, 000 years B.P.) were discovered at **Porc Epic near Dire Dawa,** and **Kibish around Lower** Omo (in 1967). In 2004, Kibish fossils were re-dated to 195, 000 B. P, the oldest date in the world for modern Homo sapiens.
- **Homo sapiens Idaltu, found in Middle Awash in 1997, lived about 160, 000 years B.P**

CULTURAL EVOLUTION: STONE TOOLS

- Cultural evolution is related to technological changes that brought socio-economic transformation on human life. It can be conventionally grouped in to
 - 1. Stone Age,
 - 2, Bronze Age and
 - 3. Iron Age.

CULTURAL EVOLUTION: STONE TOOLS

- Stone tools had been the first technologies to be developed by human beings. By taking **their features, ways and period of production**, stone tools can be grouped in to
 - 1.Mode I (Olduwan, which was named based on the first report made at Olduvai Gorge, Tanzania),
 - 2.Mode II (Acheulean, named after the first report at St. Acheul, France) and
 - 3.Mode III (Sangoon).

CULTURAL EVOLUTION: STONE TOOLS

- The Mode I stone tools are mainly characterized by crude and mono-facial styles, and were produced by the direct percussion.
- Mode II stone tools were produced by indirect percussion, by using hand-ax or hammer, and mainly characterized by bifacial, pointed and convex features.
- Mode III stone tools are characterized by flexible and finest form of production by the use of obsidian.

2. NEOLITHIC REVOLUTION (AGRI-CULTURAL)

- ◉ During the Neolithic period human beings transformed from mobile to sedentary way of life. This was a radical shift involving changes from hunting and gathering to the domestication of plants and animals.
- ◉ Climatic change and increased hunter-gatherers' population resulted in the declining number of animals and availability of plants. As food gatherers were already aware of growing cycle of most of grass types, they began to thickly grow those, which were most common and yielded seeds that are more edible. The big animals, which depended on dense bushes for sustenance, were reduced by hunting and animals that people were able to domesticate easily were smaller ones.

DOMESTICATION OF PLANTS AND ANIMALS

- The process of domestication took place independently in the various parts of the world.
- In Ethiopia and the Horn chiefly in the more elevated and wetter-parts, people cultivated plants including Teff (*Eragrotis teff*), dagussa (*Eleusine coracana*), nug (*Guzotia abyssinica*), enset (*Ensete ventricosum*) etc. The domestication of enset plant (*Ensete edule*) reduced shifting cultivation (continuous clearing of new plots), slowing down soil exhaustion.

EVIDENCES :THE EXISTENCE OF NEOLITHIC MATERIAL CULTURE

- ◉ The discovery of polished axes, ceramics, grinding stones, beads, stone figures and animal remains in sites like **Emba-Fakeda around Adigrat** in Tigray as well as **Aqordat and Barentu** in Eritrea evinces the existence of Neolithic material culture.
- ◉ The **Gobodara rock shelter** near Aksum has provided us agricultural stone tools. Remains associated with domesticated cattle, chickpeas and vegetables have been excavated from Lalibela Cave on the southeastern shore of Lake Tana.

EVIDENCES :THE EXISTENCE OF NEOLITHIC MATERIAL CULTURE

- ◎ Stone tools used for cutting grass and grass like plants as well as rock paintings of domesticated animals have been found at Laga Oda rock shelter near Charchar

EVIDENCES THE EXISTENCE OF NEOLITHIC MATERIAL CULTURE

- Evidence for domesticated cattle also comes from around Lake Basaqa near Matahara. Playa Napata and Kado in the Sudan, Cyrenaica in Libya and Futajalon in West Africa were among known places of domestication of animals like Nidamawa and Zebu (*Bos indicus*) cattle that in due course expanded to Ethiopia and the Horn

2.3. THE PEOPLING OF THE REGION

2.3.1. LANGUAGES AND LINGUISTIC PROCESSES

- 2.3.1. Languages and Linguistic Processes
- Ethiopia and the Horn in general is marked by ethnic and linguistic diversity. There are about 90 languages with 200 dialects in Ethiopia and the Horn. Beneath this apparent diversity, there is some degree of unity. Linguists classify languages of Ethiopia and the Horn into two major language super families. These are Afro-Asiatic and Nilo-Saharan.

THE PEOPLES OF THE REGION

- **A. Afro-Asiatic:** this super family is sub-divided into the following families:
- **1.1. Cushitic:** linguists divided this language family into four branches
 - 1.1.1: Northern: is represented by Beja, spoken in northwestern Eritrea bordering the Sudan
 - 1.1.2 Central: Agaw includes Awign, Kunfel, Qimant; Hamtanga and Bilen.
 - 1.1.3 Eastern: this includes diversified linguistic groups like Afar, Ale, Arbore, Baiso, Burji, Darashe, Dasanech, Gedeo, Hadiya, Halaba, Kambata, Konso, Libido, Mosiye, Oromo, Saho, Sidama, Somali, Tambaro, Tsemai, etc.
 - 1.1.4 Southern: represented by Dhalo in Kenya and Nbugua in Tanzania.
- **1.2 Semitic: is divided into two:**
 - 2.1 North: Ge'ez, Rashaida (spoken around Eritrea-Sudanese border); Tigre (spoken in Eritrean Lowland); Tigrigna (spoken in highland Eritrea and Tigray).
 - 2.2. South: is further divided into two
 - 2.1.1 Transverse: Amharic, Argoba, Harari, Silte, Wolane and Zay.
 - 2.1.2. Outer: Gafat (extinct), Gurage and Mesmes (endangered).
- **1.3. Omotic: Anfillo**, Ari, Bambasi, Banna, Basketo, Bench, Boro-Shinasha, Chara, Dawuro, Dime, Dizi, Dorze, Gamo, Ganza, Gayil, Gofa, Hamar, Hozo, KachamaGanjule, Karo, Keficho, Konta, Korete, Male, Melo, Nayi, Oyda, Sezo, Shekkacho, Sheko, Wolayta, Yem, Zayse etc. Among its groups, Omoto includes Wolayta and Gamo while main Gonga is Keficho.
- **B. Nilo-Saharan:** Anywa, Berta, Gumuz, Kacipo-Balesi, Komo, Kunama, Kwama, Kwegu, Majang, Mi'en, Murle, Mursi, Nara, Nu'er, Nyangatom, Opo, Shabo, Suri and Uduk

THE PEOPLING OF THE REGION

2.3.1. LANGUAGES AND LINGUISTIC PROCESSES

- Language classification did not remain static. Factors like population movements, warfare, trade, religious and territorial expansion, urbanization etc. have resulted in intense linguistic processes that forced languages to be affected. In this process, some languages died out or have been in danger of extinction while others thrived off the social phenomenon that is evidently observed.

2.3.2. SETTLEMENT PATTERNS

- A settlement pattern, the distribution of peoples across the landscape, is the results of long historical processes in northeast Africa. In some areas, settlement was dense and in other areas sparse. Some people inhabited extensive highlands and others the lowlands. Based on historical linguistic and history of inter-peoples relations, studies indicate that environmental, socio-economic, and political processes significantly shaped and reshaped the spatial distribution of peoples in the region.

ECONOMIC ACTIVITY

- The domestication of plants and animals gave humanity two interdependent modes of life: agriculture and pastoralism. While there may be pure pastoralists, it is very rare to think of a farmer without a head of cattle or two. Likewise, in Ethiopia and the Horn, these two forms of livelihood have coexisted and quite often interrelated. Yet, topographic features and climatic conditions largely influenced economic activities in Ethiopia and the Horn.



ECONOMIC ACTIVITY :THE PLATEAUS

- The plateaus have sustained plough agriculture for thousands of years supporting sizable populations. Majority of the populations were engaged in mixed farming. It is here that sedentary agriculture had been started and advanced at least since 10, 000 years B. P. by the Cushites, Semites and Omotic groups.
- The major economic activity of the Omotic has been
- mixed farming and trade in northern Omo while southern Omo have predominantly practiced pastoralism and fishing. Many of the Omotic groups have also been famous in metallurgy, weaving and other crafts

ECONOMIC ACTIVITY : EASTERN LOWLAND REGION

- A predominantly pastoral economy has characterized the eastern lowland region since early periods. Pastoral economy namely the production of camel, goat, and cattle has been the most common economic practice among the Afar, Saho and Somali as well as Karayu and Borana Oromo. While the Afar and Karrayu have depended on the Awash River, the Somali have owed a great deal to Wabi Shebelle and Genale (Jubba) Rivers.

ECONOMIC ACTIVITY :WESTERN LOWLAND REGION

- In the sparsely populated western lowland region, the dominant economic formations were pastoralism, shifting agriculture, fishing, apiculture and hunting. For instance, sorghum, millet, cotton and others have been largely cultivated in the lowlands along Ethio-Sudanese border since antiquity. The Nilotes along the Blue Nile and Baro-Akobo Rivers have been shifting cultivators where sorghum has been a staple food. Among majority Nilotic communities, cattle have high economic and social values. Berta and other Nilotes had trade and other social contacts with northern Sudan.

RELIGIOUS DYNAMICS IN ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN

- ① 1. Indigenous Religion
- ② 2. Judaism
- ③ 3. Christianity
- ④ 4. Islam